Reconfirming India's links with Afghan elites, the official stated that the only reason Pashtuns would choose India over Pakistan is because they want their 'elite status' back in Afghanistan. 'Pakistan has made them Jihadis'. Confirming that the R&AW maintains links with the Taliban, the official claims that such covert contacts don't last long. Finding the Taliban's philosophy 'repugnant', the official said that engaging with the Taliban openly 'was a very difficult choice' in 1996.[179] Another former top officer of India's military intelligence said that when in office, while he viewed the Taliban as Pakistan's proxy, he was open to building contacts with them and gave adequate instructions in that order to his junior officers posted in Afghanistan.[180] Most of such contacts, however, were made after 2001 and not before. According to Sood, former R&AW chief, India didn't really have a 'game-plan' on Afghanistan pre-2001. 'We didn't make any concerted attempt, it was sporadic effort. If Rabbani said something then we would sit together and chat about it,' and see what could be done.[181] Not expecting the Taliban to reach Kabul, Sood considers its rise as 'a shock' to the R&AW, which left the latter 'numb for a while'.[182] On the question of engaging with the other non-Taliban Pashtuns, Sood hinted that though the R&AW tried to build networks, the killing of Najibullah was a massive blow:

> [The] rest of the Pashtuns were not willing to talk, they were too scared. And we didn't want to upset them because at that time we were also not very sure how it was going to play out. And remember, the Taliban was Pakistan-based so the proper assessment whether all Taliban were Pashtun or Pashtuns are Taliban was not made fully.[183]

For the same reason, R&AW had refused to engage with Hekmatyar who sent secret signals to India in October 1994 when he lost Pakistan's support in the wake of the Taliban's rise, and by when New Delhi for its part had begun consolidating its relations with Rabbani and Massoud. While it is unclear whether the ISI knew about Hekmatyar's contacts with R&AW, a faction within the covert agency was nervous that abandoning Hekmatyar for the Taliban might wreck ISI's efforts in Kashmir as a lot of Kashmiri insurgents had received training in Hekmatyar's camps.[184] Sood confirms that India's non-engagement with the Taliban or Hekmatyar (whom they accepted as part of the Rabbani government until the time it lasted in 1992) was not as much about ideology as it